

Apple iPad exchange

Some Apple stores are exchanging old iPads for the new 4th Generation ones, if bought in the last 30 days



Sony Xperia gets Jelly Bean

Rumours say the 2012 range of Sony Xperia devices are likely to receive an update to the Jelly Bean OS soon

Ultrabooks Test

HOW WE TESTED

Not just for this comparison test alone, but this is how we generally test laptops for reviews conducted throughout the year in the magazine and online on the website.

Prepping

We never benchmark a laptop's performance with the way the OS and the software is, out of the box. We uninstall bloatware, download and install the latest drivers via Windows Update or the manufacturer website. We do this to ensure none of the pre-bundled software or their corresponding services has any effect on the laptop's performance score. After this step, we're ready to benchmark the laptops.

Benchmarking

We run a range of industry standard software benchmarks to measure a laptop's hardware capability and overall performance – PC Mark Vantage, 3D Mark and CineBench, to name

a few. We have added a series of tests to measure display quality too. We also measure performance with a bunch of subjective tests consistent across all laptops – for e.g., watching a movie at fixed volume and screen brightness to drain out a laptop's battery, running graphics benchmarks to ascertain a laptop's GPU capabilities, and more.

Feature listing

Here we take a look at all the features offered by a laptop, be it the range of connectivity options it provides, ports that it is supposed to have or the operating system it actually comes bundled with, and scrutinize it for anything it promises to deliver but doesn't. To put it more plainly, if a laptop claims it comes with 6 GB of RAM, we check whether it actually has 6 GB of RAM or not. We do this for all the laptops, against almost all the parameters that affect one's buying decision.

Ergonomics

While look and feel can be a matter of personal preference to some extent, determining the best ergonomic design is a matter of scientific principles. In determining the Design & Usability score for every laptop, we take into account several factors like build quality, materials used, quality and placement of hinges, keyboard usage quality and feel as well as the comfort, palmrest real estate, touchpad response quality, etc., and break it down exhaustively to arrive at a cumulative score for ergonomics, design and general usability aspects of the laptop. What we also have to critically check for is the quality of the display. More points for the ones that aren't reflective and have better viewing angles.

After going through this process for each and every laptop, we arrive at a final score based on a formula with assigned weighted scores for performance, design, and features.

tion, with the black/dark grey on the lid and the keyboard deck, and the crimson red base, looks rather unique. The brushed metal finish on its lid and the palmrest area attracts fingerprints, surprisingly. It's very well built, there is no flex anywhere on the chassis. Its keyboard with island-styled keys is extremely comfortable to type on and their response is consistent. The HP Envy 4's touchpad has a brushed metal imprint, and has a thin trench dug all around it, giving it some elevation. This is by far the best built ultrabook in the price bracket.

The two Lenovo IdeaPad ultrabooks look exactly the

same, and hence we will talk about them together. The IdeaPad U410 looks very similar to a MacBook Pro 13, albeit the U410's 14-inch display. The gun-metal colour on its lid and keyboard deck contrasts well with the chrome frame along the sides. The U410's design is uniformly thick. Its display hinge is the most solid across all ultrabooks, it doesn't vibrate or move around when subjected to sudden jerks. Open the lid and you get the well spaced out keyboard that is very easy to get accustomed to. Among all ultrabooks in this category, this keyboard has the best feel and user experience,

slightly ahead of the Envy 4. The layout is just perfect, and has adequate amount to travel to make this universally acceptable. The U410 isn't the thinnest,



Dell Inspiron 14z Ultrabook

but it retains the practicality of a great keyboard, which a blade thin ultrabook mostly doesn't.

Samsung has carried forward the same design from its previous generation Series 5 ultrabooks to the Ivy Bridge series. Its design is functional, but you do feel some flex at certain parts on the chassis, due to the thinner materials used. This is one of the reasons why the HP Envy, the Lenovo IdeaPad U410 and even the Toshiba Satellite U840w score a lot better in terms of build quality than the Samsung Series 5. Brushed metal finish seems to be common across a majority of ultrabooks, but this one is slightly shinier than most. Open it up and the keyboard deck is fairly uncluttered.

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